

About the pharmaceutical collection

The pharmaceutical collection contains claim and payment information from pharmacists for subsidised dispensings.

- The Pharmaceutical Data web tool presents information on pharmacy prescriptions for individuals. The Pharmaceutical Data web tool can be used to search, view and download summary data about initial dispensings and dispensings that were dispensed in the community and funded by the New Zealand Government. The data presented is sourced from Health New Zealand - Te Whatu Ora's Pharmaceutical Collection.

Using the collection

Start date

The collection started in 1 July 1992.

Records from before 1996 have been archived, but are available on request.

Guide for use

The pharmaceutical collection has gone through 2 major changes since 1992.

Repeat prescriptions were introduced in 1996.

The major drug key changed from Medicode, allocated by Sector Services, to Pharmacode (pharmacy stock code) in 1998.

Other small structural changes are made to the collection each year.

All money values are assumed to include GST, unless otherwise stated.

Identification of co-prescribing, which is the analysis of drugs being prescribed and taken together, has been a problem with historical data.

Collection methods — guide for providers

The main source of the data is Sector Operations' GTPS. Extra data is provided by:

- Stats NZ geographical and census data — claimant data is geocoded by the national collections and reporting geocoding engine
- Sector Operations — provider reference data
- Pharmac — the Pharmac Schedule and mappings.

Frequency of updates

Health NZ gets monthly extracts from Sector Operations and Pharmac.

Security of data

The collection is accessed by authorised Health NZ and Pharmac staff for the purposes of:

- maintenance
- data quality
- audit
- analytics.

Authorised members of the Ministry of Health and Health NZ have access to the collection for analytical purposes, using Business Objects and the secure Health Information Network. Business Objects contains a subset of the data described in the Data Dictionary.

Access to the collection requires approval from Health NZ.

Business Objects is being decommissioned.

Privacy issues

We are required to make sure that the release of information meets the conditions of any legislation related to the privacy of health information. In particular the:

- Official Information Act 1982
- Privacy Act 2020
- Health Information Privacy Code 2020.

Information available to the general public is of a statistical and non-identifiable nature. A data release policy covers approval where appropriate from a health ethics committee.

We are responsible for the privacy of NHI-related information. NHIs were provided for approximately 97% of dispensings in 2010.

National reports and publications

Summarised pharmaceutical data can be accessed using the Pharmaceutical data web tool and in Pharmac's annual reports.

Data provision

Customised datasets or summary reports are available on request. These can be electronic or on paper.

Our team can help to define the specifications for a request and are familiar with the strengths and weaknesses of the data.

We also offer a peer review service to make sure Health NZ data is reported appropriately when published by other organisations.

Citation

Health New Zealand. 2026. Pharmaceutical Data web tool version 07 August 2026 (data extracted from the Pharmaceutical Collection on 09 July 2026). URL:

<https://tewhatuora.shinyapps.io/pharmaceutical-data-web-tool/> (Accessed OFTEN).